

Starlight Post Office

Licensed classic · labyrinth edition

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Owl at the Door

The letter arrived before the sun did.

Zara found it wedged under the front door at six in the morning, when the sky was still that particular navy blue that belongs only to the last hour before dawn. She had come downstairs for a glass of water and had almost stepped on it — a cream-coloured envelope, thick as a book, sealed with dark blue wax pressed into the shape of a crescent moon. Her name was on the front in ink that seemed to shift between silver and violet depending on how she tilted it.

She took it to the kitchen table and stared at it the way she stared at maths problems that were more interesting than difficult.

Her twin brother Leo appeared nine minutes later, wearing his dressing gown the wrong way round and carrying a torch he didn't need because he'd already turned the kitchen light on. Leo always brought a torch anyway, on the principle that you might not always know when you'd need one until you did.

"You got a letter," he said.

"We got a letter," Zara corrected. She turned the envelope over. On the back, in slightly smaller script: Zara & Leo — Starlight Post Office, Dept. of Urgent Deliveries.

Leo put the torch down on the table. "Is this from a real place?"

"The wax is warm," Zara said. "As if it was sealed very recently." She pressed one finger to the crescent moon seal. Something pressed back — gently, the way a friendly cat pushes its head into your palm.

They looked at each other. They had the same dark eyes, the same habit of going quiet before deciding to be brave. In eleven years of being twins, they had learned to read each other's silences the way other people read sentences, and the silence between them now said: we're opening it.

The seal parted without tearing, as if it had been waiting to be asked.

Inside was a single card, the colour of midnight. Pressed into its surface in silver letters — raised so you could feel each word with your fingertips — was the following:

YOU HAVE BEEN SELECTED AS TEMPORARY POSTAL APPRENTICES FOR THE STARLIGHT POST OFFICE. YOUR FIRST SHIFT BEGINS AT DUSK. LOOK FOR THE OWL.

Below that, smaller: P.S. He prefers to be addressed as Parcel. Not Mr. Parcel. Just Parcel. He will explain the distinction himself if you forget.

"An owl," Leo said.

"At dusk," Zara said.

They looked at the window. Dawn was coming in slowly, going pink along the edges of the rooftops.

"We have a full day to wait," Leo said.

"No we don't," said Zara, already heading back upstairs for her notebook. "We have a full day to prepare."

Chapter 2 — Parcel's Introduction

He was perched on the garden gatepost at exactly quarter to dusk, which was not a time most clocks bothered to measure but which Parcel seemed to carry in the tilt of his head. He was a large tawny owl with gold-rimmed spectacles, a leather satchel worn crosswise over his breast, and an expression of professional serenity that clearly meant he had seen a great deal of the world and remained unimpressed by most of it.

He looked at Zara.

He looked at Leo.

He looked at Leo's torch.

"Good," he said. His voice was low and precise, like the click of a well-made lock. "You brought a light. Amateurs don't bring lights. This reduces my concerns by approximately thirty per cent."

"You were concerned?" Leo said.

"I am always appropriately concerned. It is part of the job." Parcel stepped off the gatepost with a single elegant movement and landed on the garden path before them. He was taller than he had appeared from a distance — nearly knee height — and the satchel at his side was stamped with a small emblem: a crescent moon inside an envelope, surrounded by seven tiny stars. "Postmaster Parcel, Starlight Post Office. First Shift Supervisor, Licensed Labyrinth Division, and Keeper of the Undeliverable."

"What's the Undeliverable?" Zara asked.

"That," Parcel said, "is Chapter Seven. We don't spoil the chapters." He turned and began walking toward the end of the garden, where the hedge met the back fence and had, until this particular dusk, never opened into anything except next door's allotment. "Follow closely. Don't touch the outgoing mail. Don't lick the seals — they're enchanted for recipient identification only. And please do not lose the route-map, which I am about to give you."

He reached into his satchel and produced two small cards, one for each of them. Each card showed the same map: a town that looked like their town, except the streets were named after different kinds of weather and the parks were labeled with things like Meadow of Forwarded Dreams and Sorting Square.

"Is this real?" Leo asked.

"It's realer than what you're used to," Parcel said, and stepped through the hedge. The hedge parted for him the way a crowd parts for someone who clearly knows where they're going.

Zara and Leo stepped through after him.

The garden was gone. The town ahead of them was silvered with early starlight, lamps just beginning to glow in windows shaped like envelope flaps, streets laid out in patterns that looked — from the slight rise of the lane ahead — like a postmark seen from above. The air smelled of warm paper, distant rain, and something sweet and indefinable, the smell of correspondence that has traveled very far.

"Welcome," Parcel said, adjusting his spectacles, "to your first delivery route."

Chapter 3 — Letters by Starlight

The first rule of the Starlight Post Office, Parcel explained as they walked, was that letters could only travel in starlight.

Not sunlight. Not lamplight. Not the blue-white glare of a telephone screen or a passing car's headlights. Only starlight — old light, traveling for years before it arrived, carrying with it the patience of distance. Daytime post was ordinary post, handled by ordinary means. But letters with things that truly needed saying — the ones that took months to write, the ones drafted and discarded a dozen times before a final honest version emerged — those required something slower, more earnest, and considerably more nocturnal.

"Why starlight specifically?" Zara asked, walking beside Parcel with her notebook open.

"Because starlight doesn't hurry," Parcel said. "A letter delivered in a rush arrives before the reader is ready. A letter delivered by starlight arrives at exactly the right moment." He paused at a post-box set into the side of a building shaped like a giant ink bottle. The box was overflowing with envelopes that glowed very faintly at the edges, as if their contents were luminescent. "Tonight's batch. Sort by district."

He handed Zara a bundle and Leo a bundle and watched them work. The envelopes were warm and slightly buzzing, not unpleasantly — more like the vibration of a tuning fork that had just been struck and was still ringing.

Leo sorted by the street names on the front: Cumulus Lane, Drizzle Road, Frost Terrace. Zara sorted by urgency — the letters with two moon-seals needed to go first, single moon-seals second. The ones sealed with a small golden sun were special deliveries for people who had been waiting a very long time.

"The gold ones," Parcel said, watching her notice them. "Those are the difficult ones."

"Difficult how?" Zara asked.

"They contain apologies. Or confessions. Or, in one memorable case, a recipe for a cake that a grandmother wanted to give her grandchildren before she forgot that she'd invented it. Difficult doesn't mean bad. It means they required courage to write." He took the gold-sealed letters gently and placed them in a separate compartment in his satchel, padded with what appeared to be velvet. "We treat those with particular care."

They set off along Cumulus Lane, letters tucked under their arms, Parcel floating silently above when the route

demanded — checking addresses from above, calling corrections down to them, once landing precisely on a letterbox to hold it open while Leo worked out whether the envelope would fit with its wings folded.

Above them, the stars seemed brighter than usual, or perhaps they were simply paying closer attention. Zara noticed that when she held a letter up to the sky, she could sometimes see a faint shape in the light through it — not words exactly, but an outline of feeling: warmth, nervousness, relief, love expressed sideways in the way people who aren't used to saying it directly sometimes do.

"Parcel," she said. "Do you read them?"

"Never." He said it without hesitation. "I carry them. Reading is for the recipient."

"But you know what's in them."

A pause. One wing adjusted. "I know what they weigh," he said finally. "A letter full of unsaid things is heavier than you'd expect."

Chapter 4 — Wrong Address, Wrong World

The trouble began with number Fourteen.

Fourteen Frost Terrace was a perfectly normal address except that Frost Terrace, as Zara discovered when they turned the corner, appeared twice on the route-map. There was a Frost Terrace that bent left around a lamp-post shaped like a crocus, and a Frost Terrace that bent right around a lamp-post shaped like a different crocus, slightly taller, with an extra leaf. Leo insisted they were different plants. Zara insisted they were the same plant rendered by someone inconsistent. Parcel, who had gone ahead to check the next post-box, was not there to adjudicate.

Leo chose left. Zara's notebook, consulted urgently, suggested right. Leo had already posted the letter.

The letter slot swallowed it. The door of number Fourteen shimmered once — just once — and the lamp-post behind them went from crocus-shaped to something that looked rather more like a tulip.

The street was still called Frost Terrace. The houses were still the same soft grey stone. But the letterboxes were now painted a different colour, the dustbins had unfamiliar stamps on them, and the sky overhead had two moons — one full, one crescent — in a configuration that did not appear on any astronomical chart Zara had studied.

"Leo," she said carefully.

"I see the moons," he said.

"We've taken the wrong branch," she said. "We're in the parallel town."

Parcel reappeared from around the far corner, landed between them with quiet urgency, and looked at the sky with the expression of someone who has told apprentices not to lose the route-map and is now looking at the consequences.

"The parallel town," he confirmed. "It mirrors Starlight Post's delivery area exactly, with minor variations. The addresses are the same. The streets are the same. The residents are the same — mostly." He glanced at the door of number Fourteen. "But letters delivered here don't reach their intended recipients. They reach their parallel-selves instead."

"Is that bad?" Leo asked.

"It depends on the letter. Parallel selves sometimes need the same things. But correspondence meant for your specific self from your specific person lands differently when delivered across dimensions. It loses..." He searched for the word. "Accuracy."

"We need to get the letter back," Zara said.

"The letter has already been delivered," Parcel said. "It can't be undelivered."

"Then we need to explain to whoever received it."

Parcel looked at her for a long moment. His gold-rimmed spectacles caught the double-moonlight. "I take back eight of my remaining concerns," he said. "That was the correct answer. Come with me."

Chapter 5 — The Other Side of the Address

The resident of Fourteen Frost Terrace (parallel branch) was a woman named Mrs. Calloway who had been expecting a letter for three months and was therefore understandably startled when two children and an owl knocked at her door at night.

She was, Parcel explained in a low pre-door-knock briefing, the parallel version of the letter's intended recipient. Her counterpart on the correct branch was also named Mrs. Calloway, also waited for correspondence, but had not received it tonight by an accident of crocus-counting.

"Do we tell her the truth?" Leo whispered.

"We tell her the relevant truth," Parcel said. "Which is that she has received something meant for someone like her, and that we need her help to ensure the right person receives a copy."

The door opened. Mrs. Calloway was small, sharp-eyed, wearing a cardigan that had been mended at the elbows so many times it had become a different colour from the original. She looked at Parcel without surprise.

"A Starlight delivery," she said. "I knew it would be tonight. The crescent on the envelope — I could feel it in the letterbox."

She produced the letter from her cardigan pocket. She had not opened it, which Zara found quietly astonishing. Three months of waiting, and she had carried it in her pocket for ten minutes without opening it.

"You didn't read it," Zara said.

"It doesn't belong to me," Mrs. Calloway said simply. "I could feel that too. It's addressed to a Maggie Calloway. My name is Maren. It's close, but it's not me." She held it out. "Can you make sure it finds the right one?"

"We'll duplicate it," Parcel said. He produced from his satchel a small device that looked like a wax seal but worked differently — a letter pressed against it produced a perfect twin, same weight, same warmth, same contents as if the original were made of something that could be in two places at once. "One copy returns to the correct branch. You keep the original, Mrs. Calloway. It isn't yours, but you waited for it honestly, and the post office recognizes that."

Maren Calloway looked at the letter in her hands. Her eyes went bright, briefly.

"The parallel town doesn't get much proper post," she said. "Mostly we get things that were meant for someone else."

"That will change," Parcel said, in a tone that was a promise wearing professional clothing. "We will open a parallel route by spring."

She waved them off from the doorstep, both moons large and calm above her roof. Leo checked the route-map very carefully before they stepped back through the crossing-point, marking the crocus-count difference with his own pencil in a margin Parcel hadn't used.

Zara looked back once. Maren Calloway was standing in her doorway, holding a letter that wasn't quite hers, reading it anyway — gently, as if borrowing something she intended to return.

Chapter 6 — The Constellation Room

Parcel led them off-route after the third delivery, down a lane that didn't appear on the route-map but which the map seemed to know about anyway — the card warmed in Zara's hand as they turned, as if recognizing a familiar path.

The lane ended at a door set into a wall of old brick, round-topped, with a lock shaped like a star. Parcel unlocked it with one precise talon-touch and led them in.

The room beyond was circular, high-ceilinged, and entirely dark except for the ceiling, which was not dark at all. Constellations blazed across it — dozens of them, hundreds — but not the ones from astronomy books. These were shaped wrong, or rather shaped differently: a pattern of five stars in the shape of an envelope. Seven stars curled into a letter C. A long chain of seventeen stars strung in something that looked, unmistakably, like a sentence.

"What are these?" Leo asked, his torch off, unnecessary, the ceiling doing all the work.

"Undelivered letters," Parcel said.

The room went very quiet.

"When a letter cannot reach its recipient — not because of a wrong address, but because the recipient is no longer reachable — the letter doesn't disappear. It doesn't go into a lost-post bin or an unclaimed pile. It goes up." Parcel tilted his head toward the ceiling. "The words find each other. They rearrange into light. Every undelivered letter from every Starlight route since the office opened is somewhere in this ceiling."

Zara stared up. The envelope-shaped constellation was made of five very different stars — she could see it now — different ages, different temperatures, different distances from this world. "They're real stars," she said. "Outside. In the actual sky."

"The post office doesn't create them," Parcel said. "It only names them. Someone's letter was looking for somewhere to go. The sky offered." He moved to the centre of the room, where a wooden lectern held an open book — thick as a dictionary, filled with handwritten entries: dates, names, and next to each name, a constellation map with a small note about what the letter had contained. August 14th, 1943: a letter from a soldier to his daughter about a bird he'd watched from a window. December 3rd, 1997: a letter from a grandmother explaining where she'd hidden the family's best recipe, the one no one had been able to reconstruct. March 7th, last year: a letter from a boy to his best friend saying the thing he'd meant to say for six months and had finally found words for.

Leo read entries silently, turning pages with great care.

"Do they know?" Zara asked. "The people who wrote them. Do they know their letters became stars?"

"Not in so many words," Parcel said. "But I think they feel it. People who've lost a letter sometimes look up at the right moment and feel something they can't quite name." He smoothed a page with one wing. "The sky keeps what the post couldn't carry."

Zara wrote three pages of notes. Leo drew the envelope-shaped constellation in his notebook. Neither of them spoke much. Some rooms earn their silence.

Chapter 7 — The Letter That Couldn't Be Finished

They found it in the deepest drawer of the Sorting Room: an envelope addressed in an uncertain hand, the ink of the address clear and deliberate but the seal unstamped, the flap unglued, the whole thing sitting open like a question that hadn't decided its answer yet.

Parcel saw them find it and made a sound low in his chest — not alarm, but the specific gravity of something he had been hoping they wouldn't encounter and was relieved they had.

"That one," he said carefully, "has been in the drawer for eleven months."

"Someone forgot to seal it?" Leo asked.

"Someone couldn't finish it."

He explained as much as the postal code allowed, which was not the whole story but was enough to understand its

shape. The letter had been begun by a man named Thomas, who was trying to write a goodbye to his neighbourhood before he moved abroad. Not a sad goodbye — he was going somewhere good, for reasons that were very good — but a goodbye that contained years of memory and gratitude and three specific things he had never said to three specific people, and every time he got to those three things, he put the letter away and didn't come back to it for weeks.

"He left," Parcel said. "He moved. He left the letter behind in a flat that is now someone else's. The new resident didn't know what it was. She brought it to us, as people sometimes do when they find unusual things on Starlight nights."

"Can we deliver it?" Zara asked.

"Not as it stands. An unfinished letter cannot be delivered. The recipient feels the gap — where the real thing should be, there's only a blank, and a blank can be more painful than silence." Parcel looked at the drawer. "We have been waiting for the right apprentices to help complete it."

"We can't write it," Leo said. "It's his letter."

"No. But you can sit with it. Read what he managed to write. And perhaps — if the post office agrees, and it has agreed by allowing you to find it — you can write a frame around what's missing. Not his words. A description of his absence. A note that explains the shape of what he meant to say."

Leo looked at Zara. Zara looked at Leo.

"A letter about the letter," she said slowly.

"A letter that carries the incomplete one," Parcel said, "and tells the recipient: this is as far as words could go. The rest was love that ran out of language."

They sat at the sorting table for a long time. The letter Parcel placed before them was gentle to handle — the paper slightly wavy where it had been pressed flat, the ink of Thomas's sentences warm and careful, the blanks at the end soft rather than harsh, like a page that had given everything it had and simply run out of paper.

Leo wrote three drafts. Zara wrote two. They combined them.

What they produced was not Thomas's letter and did not pretend to be. It was a note, written in the voice of the Starlight Post Office, explaining that the enclosed letter had been written with great intention and great love and had simply reached the limit of what one person could say in one sitting. That the blank space at the end was not emptiness. That it was everything Thomas would have written if language had one more shelf.

Parcel read it without expression, which in an owl meant he was moved.

"First class," he said, and sealed both letters together.

Chapter 8 — Delivering the Undeliverable

Thomas's neighbours — the three people who were meant to receive the three things he had never said — lived on the same street, which the route-map confirmed was reachable by the late-night starlight route if they moved quickly and the clouds cooperated.

The clouds cooperated. This sometimes happened, Parcel said, when the night had decided a delivery mattered.

The first was a shopkeeper named Mrs. Osei, who ran a small bookshop at the end of the street and who had, eleven months ago, found a note in her door thanking her for recommending a particular novel during a particular winter. She had not known who it was from. The missing name had been on Thomas's list.

She answered her door in a dressing gown and reading glasses, book in hand, and looked at the envelope Zara held out with an expression that was startled and then softened and then went very still.

"Is this from Thomas?" she asked.

"It is," Zara said.

"He moved to Portugal," Mrs. Osei said. "I heard from the estate agent." She took the letter, turned it over, felt the weight of it. "He always picked the right books," she said. "Every customer whose name he forgot, he described by what they read. The woman who likes weather. The boy who wants adventures without maps." She looked at Zara. "He would have described you as the one who takes notes."

"Is that a good description?" Zara asked.

"The best ones," said Mrs. Osei, "always are."

The second was an elderly man, Mr. Park, who had lent Thomas a ladder four years ago and had it returned before the end of the same week with a note that said simply: thank you, I know what it's like to need something at exactly the right moment. He did not appear to need explanation. He took the letter and pressed it to his chest with both hands, the way you hold something you thought you'd never have.

The third — the hardest — was a woman who had been Thomas's neighbour for six years and with whom he had had one real argument, over something small, that had never been properly resolved. He had meant to resolve it. The unfinished sentences in his letter swelled up around that section, crossed-out and rewritten and crossed-out again.

Her name was Diane. She opened the door and saw Parcel first, and her expression went from guarded to something more complicated.

"A Starlight delivery," she said.

"Yes," Leo said. He held out the letter.

She didn't take it immediately. "Is it from Tom?"

"It is."

She breathed out. It was the sound of something that had been held very tight for eleven months. She took the letter. She did not read it at the door but said quietly, to Parcel: "Will he know I received it?"

"The post office records every delivery," Parcel said. "He will know."

She nodded, and closed the door, and through the letterbox Zara heard — very faintly — the sound of an envelope opening with great care.

Parcel did not say anything for the whole walk back. But his feathers were settled, and his spectacles were very clean, and his satchel sat lighter on his shoulder.

Chapter 9 — The Parallel Town Writes Back

Two nights later, there was an unexpected delivery at the Sorting Room.

A single envelope had arrived in the overnight tray, addressed in unfamiliar ink — slightly darker than the standard starlight post, the crescent seal pressed sideways, as if done by someone working from memory rather than practice. The return address read: 14 Frost Terrace, Parallel Branch, First Left.

Maren Calloway.

Parcel read the return address and went very still in the precise way of someone who is trying to look unsurprised.

"She wrote back," Leo said.

"She wrote first," Zara said. "There wasn't an original letter to reply to. She started a correspondence."

"There is no established protocol," Parcel said, which was the most flustered he had sounded in three shifts, "for inter-branch personal correspondence initiated by a parallel resident."

"So you need one," Zara said.

"I need one."

"Write one," Leo said. "Or let her letter through and see what happens."

Parcel considered this with the gravity of someone who had maintained the rules of starlight post for twenty-seven years and was now being asked to write a new one at quarter past midnight.

"The principle of starlight post," he said slowly, "is that correspondence that truly needs to be sent will find its route. This letter arrived. Which means the route exists." He picked up the envelope with great care. "I will add a note to the official record: inter-branch correspondence, Parallel Division, initiated by resident Maren Calloway. Case number one."

"Who is it addressed to?" Zara asked.

Parcel turned the envelope over.

To whoever on the other side reads letters meant for someone else, it said. I hope you know what to do with them. I hope someone sent you one once.

Below that, in the smaller, more careful hand of someone who wasn't sure how to sign off: With regards, Maren. P.S. The second moon is smaller than it looks.

They delivered it to the main-branch Mrs. Calloway — Maggie, whose original letter had finally arrived the following evening — and Maggie read Maren's note twice, brow furrowed, then smoothed it out and put it beside her original letter on the kitchen table.

"She's me," Maggie said finally. "From somewhere else."

"In a manner of speaking," Parcel said.

Maggie considered this with the kind of calm that comes from having waited a long time for things. "Tell her the second moon is exactly the right size for where it is," she said. "And that I think we'd get on."

Parcel wrote the reply himself, for the first time in twenty-seven years.

Chapter 10 — What the Stars Remember

On their sixth night, Parcel took them back to the Constellation Room.

The ceiling was the same — blazing, vast, every undelivered letter a permanent light — but Parcel had brought something new: the registry book, open to a section they hadn't seen before. Earlier entries. Older ones. The handwriting in the oldest pages was in inks so faded they were barely visible, but when you angled the light right they came up: dates from hundreds of years ago, descriptions of letters sent upward before the Starlight Post Office existed, before anyone had a name for what happened when a letter could not reach its person.

"They were always going somewhere," Leo said, reading.

"Every letter that runs out of address," Parcel said. "Every goodbye that couldn't find its door. Every thank-you sent too late, every apology written when the person it was for had already moved beyond reach." He stood in the centre of the room, surrounded by light from decades of unfinished correspondence. "The sky has always kept them. We only started writing them down."

Zara looked up at the envelope-shaped constellation — the one she'd noticed on the first night, five stars in a careful arrangement.

"Parcel," she said. "What's that one?"

He didn't look up. He knew which one she meant.

"A letter written in 1912," he said. "From a girl about your age, to her sister who had emigrated and never written back. The girl wrote every month for two years, sending letters to an address that had stopped receiving them. The last one she wrote was the longest. It said, among other things: I don't know if these reach you. I send them because I have to. Not knowing where they go feels worse than not sending them."

The room was very quiet.

"Did the sister ever write back?" Zara asked.

"The records don't say." Parcel was still looking at the floor. "But that constellation has five stars. The letter she wrote had five paragraphs. And one of those stars is in the part of the sky that can be seen from the city where the sister settled." He paused. "I prefer to think she looked up once and felt something."

Leo had been writing since Parcel started talking, filling half a page in a notebook that he had not brought for this purpose but that seemed to have expanded to include it.

"This is the reason," Leo said quietly. "The whole reason the post office does what it does. Not just to deliver letters. To make sure that when they can't be delivered, they don't just disappear."

"Exactly so," Parcel said. "Nothing that was truly meant is wasted. The sky is very large. It keeps everything."

He closed the registry book. Above them, the ceiling burned with a year's worth, a century's worth, a millennium's worth of things that needed saying.

They walked home in silence, and both of them looked up the whole way.

Chapter 11 — The Last Delivery

On the seventh night — the last of their apprenticeship — Parcel met them at the gatepost with the satchel already full and the route-map glowing faintly in the dusk.

He looked them both over. He adjusted his spectacles. He opened the satchel and produced two small items: two silver pins shaped like the crescent-moon-in-envelope emblem of the Starlight Post Office.

"You have not lost any mail," he said. "You have not misdirected any correspondence except once, and you resolved it correctly and with character. You have helped complete a letter that had been incomplete for eleven months. You have initiated a new inter-branch correspondence protocol. And you have not, on any occasion, attempted to read any letter that was not addressed to you."

He pinned one to Zara's jacket and one to Leo's.

"These," he said, "are not ranks. They are records. The post office keeps a record of everyone who has carried its correspondence honestly. You are now part of that record."

The final delivery run took them across every street they had covered in the week: Cumulus Lane, Frost Terrace (correct branch), Drizzle Road, Sorting Square, and finally a short lane that bent down toward the crossing-point into the parallel branch, where a small letterbox had been installed — clean and new, painted in the parallel branch's slightly different shade of grey — marked with Maren Calloway's name and the notation: New Route, First Light.

Parcel had built it that afternoon.

"I told her we'd open a parallel route by spring," he said, posting three forwarded letters into the new box. "Spring arrived early."

The letters settled into the box with the quiet satisfaction of things arriving where they belong.

They walked back up to Sorting Square under a sky that seemed particularly attentive, the stars very bright, the air warm with something that wasn't quite temperature.

"Parcel," Leo said. "Will you take new apprentices after us?"

"The post office will choose them," Parcel said. "It always does. There is usually a letter involved."

"Will we know when you've found them?" Zara asked.

He considered this.

"Look up," he said, "on any clear night. If there's a new constellation — small, crescent-shaped, with the outline of an envelope — then someone has just begun their first delivery. And if you look carefully at the route below it, you might recognise the streets."

He turned, a single precise movement, and became very still on the gatepost.

"End of shift," he said. "The post office thanks you for your service. The letters thank you, in their own way." He paused. "I also thank you. In mine."

He lifted both wings once, briefly.

Then he was gone, up and away into the starlight, the satchel swinging at his side, the next route already beginning.

Chapter 12 — What Remains

Zara and Leo told no one. Not because it was a secret — the Starlight Post Office didn't require secrecy, only discretion — but because some things are so precisely the right shape that talking about them too soon makes them smaller.

Instead, they did other things.

Zara started writing letters. Real ones, not messages, not texts — letters that took more than one draft, that knew their address and meant their greeting and said the three specific things she had been saving up without knowing she was saving them. She wrote one to her grandmother, who was difficult to visit and easy to love. She wrote one to a friend who had moved schools the previous year and who Zara had always meant to stay in better touch with. She wrote one that she kept in her desk, unsealed, because she wasn't sure yet if she had the right words — but she kept it, because the Constellation Room had taught her that even an unfinished letter was better than no letter at all.

Leo kept the route-map. He knew it wasn't official — it had been given for their apprenticeship and was technically Parcel's property — but when he turned it over one morning, the back bore a small notation in Parcel's careful claw-print: First Shift Map, Zara & Leo. For their records. It had always been meant to stay.

He added to it. Not the official routes but a private map: the address where Maren Calloway lived, two moons up and a left fork past the wrong crocus. The Constellation Room, unlabeled except for a small star symbol. The lane where Thomas's neighbours lived, annotated with three names and what they had looked like when they received their letters.

The parallel town's letterbox.

He drew it carefully, in permanent ink, the way you draw something you intend to return to.

The pin on his jacket caught the light when he walked past windows. Mrs. Osei, who had received her letter from Thomas, saw it one afternoon in her bookshop and stopped mid-sentence in her recommendation and looked at him directly.

"You work for the post office," she said.

It was not a question.

"I did," Leo said. "For one week."

"Ah," said Mrs. Osei. And then, with the certainty of someone who ran a bookshop on a street that received starlight deliveries: "You'll go back."

Above the town that night, the sky was very clear. At the edge of the eastern quadrant, just where the dipper tilts toward the horizon, a small new constellation had appeared: five stars arranged like an envelope, with a single smaller star at the centre — the one that was brighter than the rest, the one that burned with the particular quality of something just beginning.

Zara stood at her bedroom window and looked at it for a long time.

Leo came in behind her, torch in hand because he always brought a torch, and stood beside her.

"New one," he said.

"Someone's first night," she said.

They watched the star at the centre burn — steadily, warmly, the way letters burn when they've been read by the right person at the right moment.

Outside, somewhere across the town, a letterbox opened in the dark to receive something delivered by starlight, by an owl with gold-rimmed spectacles, along a route that bent left past a crocus-shaped lamp-post on a night exactly cold enough to carry correspondence well.

And somewhere in a room full of undelivered light, a new page was added to the registry, and an entry was made, and nothing that was truly meant was ever lost.

THE END